Cross-owner reuse of agent skills on GitHub: predictability and construction biases of GitSkills*

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Abstract.
Agent skills are copied between repositories without a central registry, and the GitSkills dataset documents this diffusion at scale. We study whether observable characteristics of a skill and of its repository are associated with cross-owner replication of identical content, and how much of this predictability is an artifact of how the dataset was built. The rule that selects the representative copy of each content makes its location class depend on the number of copies (the probability that the representative sits in `.claude/skills/` rises from 14% to 92%, while the actual share of copies there stays at 5–13%), and about a quarter of the replicated contents exist under a single owner. After excluding the identified construction-dependent shortcuts, a Random Forest reaches an AUC of 0.73 (95% CI 0.72–0.75) for cross-owner replication on a new holdout disjoint by representative owner (25,011 contents, 10,484 owners), and a HistGradientBoosting model reduces the RMSLE of the number of owners from 0.664 to 0.625 relative to the mean baseline. The signal is modest and cross-sectional: it describes associations with observed replication among contents present in at least two repositories, under an owner-capped sampling protocol, and is not a prospective prediction of future reuse.

Keywords: agent skills; software reuse; mining software repositories; construction bias; grouped validation.

1 Introduction

1.1 Context and motivation

Agent skills are portable directories that combine structured metadata, natural-language instructions, and optional scripts and reference materials. At their core, a `SKILL.md` file specifies how an LLM-based agent should perform a task, including the constraints it must follow and the resources it may use [Agent Skills]. Although software reuse has been extensively studied [Haefliger et al. 2008, Lopes et al. 2017], agent skills introduce

*Data and code: `https://github.com/podorize/skillreuse`.

distinct challenges because their distribution does not require a centralized registry or package management system. Instead, skills can be replicated by copying their directories across repositories. However, the presence of identical skill content in multiple repositories does not necessarily indicate independent adoption. Such replication may reflect characteristics of the skill itself, such as clarity and portability, or external factors, including its inclusion in templates or catalogs, automated installation by development tools, and duplication across projects maintained by the same account. Consequently, observed replication patterns reflect a combination of artifact characteristics and distribution contexts, making it difficult to distinguish potentially meaningful reuse from other forms of duplication.

The GitSkills dataset provides an opportunity to investigate these patterns at scale by documenting skill occurrences, distinct contents, and associated repository metadata [Destefanis et al. 2027]. Previous research has examined defects in skill specifications [Zhang et al. 2026], the effectiveness of skills in software engineering tasks [Han et al. 2026], and the evolution of prompts in software repositories [Tafreshipour et al. 2025]. Building on this literature, the present study investigates whether observable characteristics of agent skills and their repositories are associated with replication across distinct GitHub owners. It also examines a related methodological concern: whether the procedures used to construct the dataset introduce systematic biases that influence the apparent predictability of such replication.

1.2 Research problem

This study investigates **cross-owner replication**, defined as the presence of identical `SKILL.md` content, identified by its `content_hash`, in repositories belonging to at least two distinct GitHub owners. Each distinct content constitutes one observation, and an owner is defined as the account identified by the prefix of a repository's full name. The primary prediction target, `cross_owner`, indicates whether a content appears under two or more owners, while the secondary target, `owner_count`, measures the number of distinct owners associated with that content. Although counting owners provides a more meaningful approximation of diffusion than counting repositories, it does not establish independent adoption: multiple accounts may belong to the same individual or organization, and identical content may be propagated through templates, catalogs, or automated installation tools.

The analysis is restricted to contents observed in at least two repositories (`repository_count >= 2`). Within this population, the objective is to distinguish replication across owners from duplication within a single owner's repositories, rather than to predict whether an arbitrary new skill will ever be reused. This restriction also explains the high prevalence of cross-owner replication: 75.3% in the full eligible population, and about 80% in the capped development sample and the holdout, where the sampling protocol raises it further. Moreover, the study adopts a cross-sectional predictive design: both the attributes and the targets are derived from the same July 2026 repository snapshot. Consequently, repository characteristics such as stars, forks, and last-push dates may have been observed after replication occurred. The models therefore assess associations with observed replication rather than predicting future adoption. Accordingly,

the findings are interpreted as predictive associations, without claims of causality or skill quality [Shmueli 2010].

Two methodological challenges further complicate the analysis. **The first concerns the measurement of reuse.** The number of repositories containing identical content (`repository_count`) may overstate diffusion because it includes copies maintained by the same owner. In the full population of contents appearing in at least two repositories, 24.7% occur exclusively under a single owner, a proportion that reaches 28.0% in the development set. Furthermore, one account accounts for approximately 12% of the development observations. These patterns indicate that repository counts conflate cross-owner replication with within-owner duplication, motivating the use of owner-based targets.

The second challenge concerns the construction of predictive attributes. GitSkills retains detailed metadata for only one representative occurrence of each distinct content. This representative is selected by prioritizing certain directory locations, particularly `.claude/skills/`, followed by a deterministic alphabetical ordering of repositories and paths. As the number of occurrences increases, so does the likelihood that at least one copy resides in a preferred location. Consequently, the representative's location class, along with the availability of commit-history information associated with that location, can encode information about the number of copies through the selection procedure itself. Such attributes may therefore produce misleading predictive signals unrelated to the characteristics that explain replication. To mitigate this problem, the main models exclude the identified construction-dependent variables, while their effects are examined separately. Nevertheless, the remaining repository and path attributes still describe the selected representative, so the exclusion does not eliminate every potential effect of the selection procedure.

Together, these challenges motivate a predictive framework that distinguishes cross-owner replication from within-owner duplication while accounting for identifiable dataset-construction biases. The evaluation combines owner-grouped validation, controls for owner concentration, and a separate holdout disjoint by representative owner. Because the research hypotheses and evaluation protocol were finalized after an initial exploratory phase, only the single evaluation of the frozen models on the new holdout is treated as confirmatory; results obtained during development remain exploratory.

1.3 Objectives and research questions

- **RQ1 — Construction biases:** to what extent do the representative-selection rule, self-copying and owner concentration confound the target and the attributes of GitSkills?
- **RQ2 — Predictability:** after excluding the identified construction-dependent shortcuts, can cross-owner reuse and the number of owners be predicted better than baselines, and is the estimate confirmed on a holdout disjoint by representative owner?
- **RQ3 — Origin of the signal:** what is the contribution of skill, repository and catalog attributes, which variables are associated with the predictions, and in which direction?

1.4 Contributions

(i) An **audit of the GitSkills representative**: we recover its rule (97.2% agreement) and show that location and history depend on the number of copies. (ii) A **protocol** for cross-owner reuse with an owner-based target, a per-owner cap, grouped validation, explicit hypotheses and confirmation on a new holdout. (iii) Evidence of a **modest predictive signal**, with a stable RMSLE gain across protocol variations, confirmed on unseen data (AUC 0.73) and decomposed into blocks by one-block ablations (exploratory). (iv) A **reproducible package** with the data revision, seeds, a five-minute reproduction path and a lock that prevents reusing the holdout.

2 Related work

2.1 Reuse, cloning and natural-language artifacts

Software reuse is studied as component adoption and as the dissemination of solutions across open ecosystems [Mockus et al. 2002, Haefliger et al. 2008], and large-scale cloning on GitHub shows that duplicated content is common [Lopes et al. 2017]; reuse may occur through dependencies, copying, templates and loosely standardized processes [Heinemann et al. 2011]. These works address mainly executable code. In agent skills, behavior is specified in natural language, and copying does not reveal whether the content was executed, adapted or adopted independently. We identify identical contents by hash, as the cloning literature does, but count distinct **owners** rather than repositories, to separate diffusion among developers from duplication by one account. The measure excludes modified copies; *reuse* is an operational term, implying no quality or adoption.

2.2 Agent skills and prompt artifacts

Research on LLMs with tool use studies selection, planning and execution of calls [Schick et al. 2023, Shen et al. 2023, Yao et al. 2023, Qin et al. 2023]. An agent skill is instead a persistent artifact, hosted in repositories, that describes procedures and conventions [Agent Skills]. GitSkills provides the corpus [Destefanis et al. 2027]; other studies analyze specification and packaging defects [Zhang et al. 2026], the effect of skills on real engineering tasks [Han et al. 2026] and the evolution of prompts [Tafreshipour et al. 2025]. None asks whether observable characteristics of a skill and its context are associated with diffusion across owners, nor how much the construction of the corpus affects that question.

2.3 Validation, leakage and construction bias

When observations from the same project or organization appear in training and evaluation, a model may memorize the group instead of learning relations that generalize [Kaufman et al. 2012]; the literature recommends grouped cross-validation [Saeb et al. 2017, Roberts et al. 2017], and nested validation separates model selection from error estimation. Models may also exploit incidental regularities [Geirhos et al. 2020, Lapuschkin et al. 2019]. In mined data there is a variant: attributes produced by the collection or deduplication procedure itself may depend on the target by

construction, without any column being derived from it. The choice of the representative in GitSkills is such a case. We treat it as a bias to be audited, and adopt owner-grouped validation, a per-owner cap, hypotheses fixed before the holdout and confirmation on disjoint data.

2.4 Modeling, explainability and research gap

We model cross-owner reuse (binary) and `log1p(owner_count)` (RMSLE) with six model families, with and without nested hyperparameter search. Explainability describes how a model combines attributes but does not turn associations into causal effects; permutation importance and partial dependence depend on the model, and correlated variables share importance [Molnar 2020, Shmueli 2010, Breiman 2001]. Our contribution is empirical and methodological for this corpus: to audit the representative bias, to redefine the target in terms of owners, and to estimate, with a pre-specified protocol and a new holdout, how much signal remains.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research design

The study is empirical, quantitative and predictive, with an interpretive layer; it measures predictive information and does not estimate causal effects [Shmueli 2010]. The **development** phase (exploratory) comprises the dataset audits, the definition of targets and feature views, grouped validation and model selection. The **confirmation** phase evaluates, once, the frozen models on a new holdout, with success criteria fixed beforehand. The full protocol, including decisions made after seeing results, is in `paper/protocol.md` (Portuguese).

3.2 Data and unit of analysis

The source is GitSkills [Destefanis et al. 2027], revision `ebab17454a7c236f8f26b183567f1a126f42e3f8`: 3,797,117 `SKILL.md` files from 282,200 repositories (July 2026), grouped into 1,877,981 distinct contents (`content_hash`). All occurrences are kept, but only one **representative** per content receives full text, repository metadata, folder listing and history. Development uses 200,000 contents chosen by `md5(content_hash || ':20261009')`, split by repository into 160,000 for development and 40,000 for test; we condition on `repository_count >= 2`, which leaves 25,918 contents from 7,128 owners in development. In the full population, 306,088 contents satisfy this condition, 230,355 of them under two or more owners. The original test partition was used in exploratory analyses and supports no confirmatory claim. The reference date for age and recency is 2026-07-20.

3.3 Representative rule and audit

GitSkills documents that the representative prefers `.claude/skills/`, with a deterministic tie-break [Destefanis et al. 2027]. We recovered the rule from all raw occur-

rences: sort by location class (`canonical`, which is essentially `.claude/skills/` in any letter case, then `skills-dir`, then `other`) and, on ties, by the smallest `(repo_full_name, path)`. It reproduces the representative in 97.2% of the 306,088 contents with at least two repositories, and the representative's class equals the best available class in 100% of them. The audit compares, by number of repositories, the fraction of contents whose representative is `canonical` with the fraction of copies that actually are, to decide whether `location_class` and `history_fetched` (history was collected only for standard locations and a sample) can be legitimate predictors.

3.4 Targets

The main target is `cross_owner = owner_count >= 2`, where `owner_count` is the number of distinct owners (prefix of `repo_full_name`) across all occurrences; the secondary target is `log1p(owner_count)`, and `log1p(repository_count)` is used for sensitivity. Counting owners removes self-copying among repositories of one account. Counts are lower bounds, since GitHub code search indexes only the default branch, files up to 384 KB and recent repositories [Destefanis et al. 2027].

3.5 Features

Table 1: Feature blocks. The main models use the first four (52 columns, the *clean* view); shortcuts enter only as a finding.

Block	n	Content
`skill`	34	structure of `SKILL.md` (size, headings, lists, code, links, front matter, scripts, folder) and file name
`repo`	8	`log1p` of stars and forks, fork flag, age, days since last push, active days, language, license
`catalog`	2	`log1p` of the number of skills in the repository; indicator of at least 10
`path`	8	depth, root, `templates`, `plugins`, `vendor`, `docs`, `packages/src`, other-tool directory

Block	n	Content
shortcuts	4	`location_class`, `history_fetched`, `commit_count`, `.claude` in the path

The shortcuts depend on the representative rule and are kept out of the main models. The attributes describe the representative, not all copies; aggregating over all copies would use the same occurrences that define the target and was avoided. Imputation (median with missing indicator), scaling and one-hot encoding (`min_frequency=10`) are fitted within each fold. Decisions on transformations (`log1p` for linear models only), redundant and constant columns and class balance follow from the feature EDA (Section 4.1). We do not resample the 80/20 imbalance of `cross_owner`: the main metrics are threshold-free, and PR AUC is read against prevalence.

3.6 Validation and per-owner cap

Validation is grouped by the **owner of the representative repository**: 3 repetitions of 3 folds (`StratifiedGroupKFold`, seeds 2027–2029, strata by `owner_count` bin), with the same partitions for all models. Disjointness concerns the representative owner only: because a content can appear under several owners, in 73% of the validation rows (mean over folds) at least one occurrence owner also appears among the occurrence owners of the training contents. The attributes contain no owner identifier, but this validation does not guarantee complete owner separation. Because a few accounts concentrate the sample, we cap the contribution at **50 contents per owner** (in `content_hash` order), leaving 17,733 contents. The value 50 was chosen *after* observing the AUC's sensitivity to concentrated owners (Section 4.4); it is a data-dependent decision. Per fold we also measure the share of validation rows whose front-matter `name` appears in training and the metrics on the subset without overlap (a joint owner–`name` grouping forms a component with 64% of the rows and was discarded).

Target population. The reported AUC does not characterize the whole ecosystem. It describes performance under a protocol that restricts owner concentration (owners with fewer contents still contribute unequal numbers, so owners are capped, not equalized): contents with at least two repositories, each owner contributing at most 50 contents to validation (an unweighted cap, not a reweighting), and, for the holdout, owners with at most 37 contents each. Skills of heavily concentrated owners are underrepresented by design, and no weighting scheme restores their share of the ecosystem.

3.7 Models, baselines and tuning

The main model is the Random Forest (100 trees for regression, 300 for classification; `max_depth=12`, `min_samples_leaf=3`, `max_features=sqrt`), with Ridge ($\alpha = 10$) and logistic regression ($C = 1$) as linear references and the prevalence and the mean and median of `log1p` as baselines. Tuning is nested: six families (linear, KNN, tree, Random Forest, Gradient Boosting, HistGradientBoosting) in two variants (default

and `RandomizedSearchCV`) on the clean view, with an outer validation of 2 repetitions of 3 owner-grouped folds and an inner search of 3 owner-grouped folds and 6 candidates (planned: 3 repetitions and 12 candidates; reduced for computational cost). The combination with the best outer mean is frozen.

3.8 Metrics, inference and interpretation

The main metrics are ROC AUC (classification) and RMSLE (regression); the secondary ones are PR AUC, Brier score, log-loss, MAE and Spearman. Comparisons are paired by (repetition, fold), with 95% CIs and a t-test with the **Nadeau–Bengio correction** for repeated samples. Five hypotheses, formulated after the exploratory phase and before the confirmation, form a family corrected by Holm ($\alpha = 0.05$); all other comparisons are exploratory: **H1** the clean attributes predict cross-owner reuse (AUC against 0.5); **H2** they reduce the RMSLE of `owner_count` (clean RF against the mean of `log1p`); **H3a/H3b** the full clean set outperforms repository+catalog and skill alone (AUC), views that differ from it by more than one block; an exploratory ablation (Section 4.3) removes exactly one block from the full set; **H4** the shortcuts add to the clean attributes (RMSLE).

Interpretation uses permutation importance of the clean RF on owner-grouped folds (per column and per block) and out-of-fold partial dependence of the frozen models (trained on each training fold, curves computed on the validation rows). Both are associative. For the binary task we also report the minority class (`cross_owner = 0`) and the performance at a threshold that maximizes the balanced accuracy on development out-of-fold predictions; the threshold is then applied, unchanged, to the saved holdout predictions, as a descriptive reading and not a new evaluation.

3.9 New holdout

The holdout gathers contents outside the 200,000 sampled, with `repository_count >= 2`, whose owners do not appear among the reused skills of the sample (development and original test), with the same cap of 50: 25,011 contents from 10,484 owners, sharing no representative owner and no content with the sample (at most 37 contents per owner, so the cap of 50 does not actually bind in the holdout; its balance comes from the exclusion of concentrated owners). Only the prevalence of `cross_owner` (80.8%) was inspected, as an integrity check. The chosen models are trained on the whole development set and evaluated **once**, with CIs by owner bootstrap (2,000 resamples). Success requires the lower AUC bound above 0.5 and the upper bound of the RMSLE difference to the baseline below zero; a lock prevents re-evaluation without explicit declaration.

4 Results

Roadmap. Sections 4.1–4.2 answer RQ1 (dataset construction introduces identifiable biases); 4.3 and 4.7 answer RQ2 (a modest predictive signal remains under the clean protocol, first on development, then on the holdout); 4.3 and 4.5 answer RQ3 (skill and repository attributes carry complementary information, per block ablation, and which variables are associated with the predictions); 4.4 and 4.6 are robustness and model-selection

checks, and the conclusions are conditional on the sampling and validation choices described in Section 3.

4.1 The target, the features and owner concentration

In development (25,918 reused contents from 7,128 owners), `owner_count` mirrors `repository_count`: mean 4.50 against 5.08, median 2 in both, P95 15 against 16. The difference is at the base: **28.0%** of the contents have `owner_count = 1` (24.7% in the full population: 75,733 of 306,088), so self-copying accounts for 11% of the total mass of `repository_count` in development. A few owners concentrate the sample: the five largest account for 24.5% of the contents together (11.9% the largest; identifiers omitted), and the largest and the fourth have on average 2.0 repositories but only 1.0 owner per content. In addition, 17.2% of the contents have no front-matter `name`, and 20.1% share it with another content, a sign of variants of the same skill.

Features. The clean view has 52 columns (49 numeric, 3 categorical) that expand to 112 after preprocessing. Missing values are rare (13 columns, at most 0.2%) and imputed by the training median with an indicator. Twenty-five numeric columns have skewness above 2; since trees are invariant to monotone transformations, we apply `log1p` only in a sensitivity analysis for linear models (Section 4.4). Eight pairs of columns have $|\rho| > 0.95$; we kept them, since trees tolerate redundancy, and read the importance of redundant columns with caution. Finally, `cross_owner` is positive for 80.4% of the development contents (80.8% in the holdout), and we do not resample.

4.2 Selection bias of the representative

The table compares, on the full population (1,877,981 contents), the fraction of contents whose representative is `canonical` with the fraction of copies that actually are.

Table 2: Effect of the representative rule, by number of repositories (full population).

Repositories	contents	representative is `canonical`	copies in `canonical`
1	1,571,893	13.3%	12.6%
2	172,624	13.8%	8.5%
3	49,535	19.5%	9.1%
4–5	36,312	24.1%	10.9%
6–10	24,142	30.4%	10.1%
11–50	19,589	57.7%	7.7%
more than 50	3,886	91.7%	5.1%

The probability that the representative is `canonical` grows from 14% to 92% with the number of copies, while the actual share of copies in that folder is flat or decreasing (5–13%): a single copy in `.claude/skills/` is enough, by the recovered rule, for the representative to be `canonical`. The representative's location class, and the commit history that exists only for standard locations, therefore **depend on the number of copies**. A control with the target `repository_count` shows the size of the

effect: with the Random Forest, the repository attributes gave an RMSLE of 0.575, but 0.604 without `history_fetched` and `commit_count` (difference +0.029, 95% CI [0.018; 0.040]), against 0.623 for the mean-of-`log1p` baseline; the location class alone (three categories) gave 0.584.

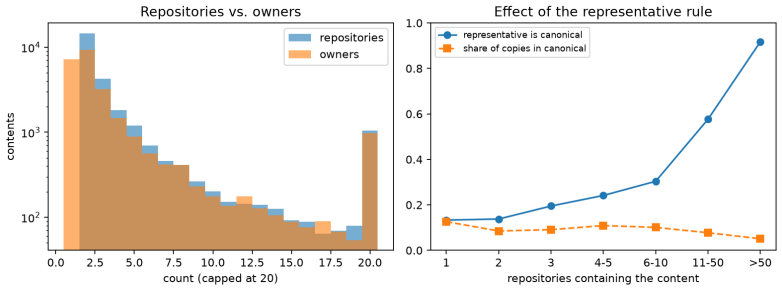


Figure 1: Distributions of repositories and owners (left) and effect of the representative rule (right)

4.3 Main protocol

With the shortcuts out, 17,733 contents (cap of 50 per owner) and owner-grouped validation, the results are:

Table 3: Performance by view (mean ± standard deviation over 9 owner-grouped folds).

View	RF AUC	logistic AUC	RF RMSLE	Ridge RMSLE
skill	0.660 ± 0.022	0.614	0.698 ± 0.007	0.713
repository	0.650 ± 0.019	0.655	0.707 ± 0.011	0.702
repository + catalog	0.666 ± 0.009	0.662	0.696 ± 0.010	0.699
path + catalog	0.579 ± 0.019	0.576	0.718 ± 0.018	0.714
clean (full)	**0.716 ± 0.024**	0.680	**0.679 ± 0.011**	0.694
clean + shortcuts	0.717 ± 0.022	0.682	0.637 ± 0.015	0.664
shortcuts only	0.500 ± 0.015	0.510	0.688 ± 0.010	0.693
baseline	0.500	0.500	0.720 (mean), 0.780 (median)	

Table 4: Hypotheses formulated before the confirmation, evaluated on development (exploratory until Section 4.7).

	Comparison	Result	95% CI of the difference	p (Holm)
H1	clean RF AUC against 0.5	0.716	+0.216 [0.173; 0.259]	< 0.001

	Comparison	Result	95% CI of the difference	p (Holm)
H2	clean RF RMSLE against the mean	0.679 vs 0.720	−0.041 [−0.049; −0.033]	< 0.001
H3a	clean against reposi-tory+catalog (AUC)	0.716 vs 0.666	+0.050 [0.017; 0.083]	0.008
H3b	clean against skill (AUC)	0.716 vs 0.660	+0.056 [0.040; 0.072]	< 0.001
H4	clean+shortcuts against clean (RMSLE)	0.637 vs 0.679	−0.042 [−0.055; −0.029]	< 0.001

The 95% intervals are unadjusted (paired differences with the Nadeau–Bengio variance correction); the p-values are Holm-adjusted over H1–H4. All five comparisons are rejected after Holm correction, and none of the conclusions depends on the adjustment alone, since every interval excludes zero. There is a real but modest signal (AUC 0.72, a 6% RMSLE reduction). The combination of blocks outperforms each view alone, which sit at AUC 0.65–0.67 against 0.72 (H3a, H3b); but these views differ from the full set by more than one block, so they do not isolate individual contributions. An exploratory ablation removes exactly one block from the full clean set (Random Forest, same folds; unadjusted 95% intervals). In classification, removing the skill block lowers the AUC by 0.044 [0.010; 0.079] and removing the repository block by 0.054 [0.034; 0.074]; removing the catalog (0.004 [−0.013; 0.021]) or the path (0.000 [−0.006; 0.007]) changes it little. In regression, removing any block raises the RMSLE slightly: skill by 0.011 [0.004; 0.017], catalog by 0.008 [0.003; 0.012], path by 0.005 [0.001; 0.009] and repository by 0.006 [−0.007; 0.019]. The evidence therefore supports complementary information from skill and repository attributes in classification, with a larger unique contribution from the repository, but only small, uneven contributions in regression. The shortcuts add to the regression (H4) but alone do not predict cross-owner reuse (AUC 0.50): their regression gain comes from correlation with the number of copies, not from cross-owner reuse.

4.4 Robustness

Table 5: Sensitivity to the treatment of concentrated owners (RF; gain relative to the mean-of-`log1p` baseline).

Treatment of concentrated owners	contents	clean RF AUC	RMSLE gain (clean)
no limit	25,918	0.747 ± 0.140	0.039

Treatment of concentrated owners	contents	clean RF AUC	RMSLE gain (clean)
exclude owners with more than 1000	21,615	0.615 ± 0.036	0.036
exclude owners with more than 500	19,567	0.708 ± 0.037	0.030
exclude owners with more than 200	18,443	0.732 ± 0.035	0.037
50 per owner	17,733	0.716 ± 0.024	0.041

The RMSLE gain is stable (0.03–0.04), but the AUC oscillates from 0.615 to 0.747: a few owners with 500 to 1000 contents lower it by 0.1, and with no limit one fold concentrates one owner and the standard deviation reaches 0.14. The cap of 50 stabilizes the estimates but is a data-dependent choice.

Other checks. (i) Fixing the location class and training within each one (owners with more than 500 contents excluded), the clean RF still beats the baseline: ΔRMSLE (model $-$ baseline) is -0.141 for `canonical` (5,439 contents; AUC 0.714), -0.013 for `skills-dir` (10,721; AUC 0.672) and -0.011 for `other` (3,810; AUC 0.828). (ii) With `repository_count` as target, the gain is the same (ΔRMSLE -0.031 against -0.030). (iii) Only 18.8% of validation rows have a `name` seen in training, and the gain persists without them (ΔRMSLE -0.039 against -0.041; AUC 0.726 against 0.716). (iv) Repository-grouped validation gave no larger estimates than owner-grouped validation (AUC 0.735 against 0.747). (v) Applying `log1p` to skewed columns improves the linear models only slightly (logistic AUC 0.680 $\rightarrow$ 0.691) and leaves the forests unchanged.

4.5 Interpretation

For the clean RF (permutation on 6 owner-grouped folds, owners with more than 500 contents excluded), for cross-owner reuse, the repository block weighs more (AUC drop of 0.104 when permuted) than skill (0.084), catalog (0.016) and path (≈ 0); among columns, `log_stars` dominates (0.056), followed by `log_forks` (0.021) and `push_recency_days` (0.016). In regression, repository (0.019) and skill (0.018) weigh similarly, and the largest column is the license (0.013), followed by catalog size (0.011) and path depth (0.005). These values are the largest measured permutation-importance decreases under the evaluated model and data distribution, not the determinants of reuse. Uncertainties are large (6 folds), and stars and forks are correlated (as are several skill-structure attributes), so permutation can split or shift importance among them unpredictably: the ranking between `log_stars` and `log_forks`, in particular, should not be read as separate effects.

The partial dependence shows the **direction** of the model's response, and may

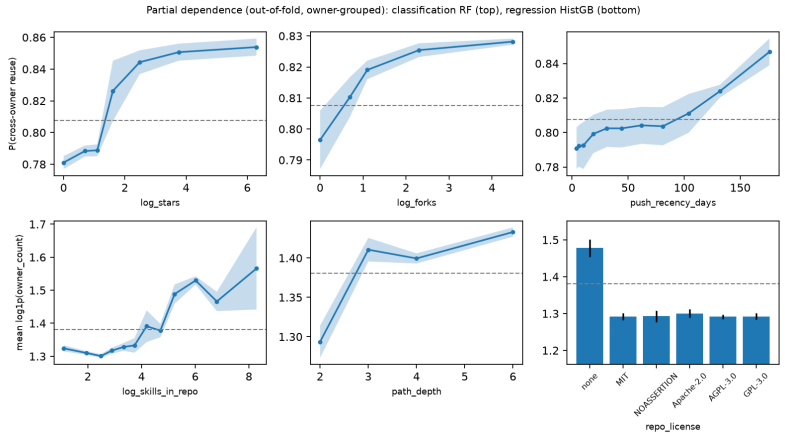


Figure 2: Out-of-fold partial dependence of the frozen models: classification RF (top) and regression HistGB (bottom); bands are ±1 standard deviation across folds, dashed lines the mean observed prediction

evaluate combinations of attributes that are rare in the data (for example many forks with no stars). The probability of cross-owner reuse rises with stars (0.78 with none to 0.85 at about 540, mostly between 1 and 12 stars) and forks (0.80 to 0.83), and also with the **time since the last push**: repositories pushed more than about 100 days ago have higher probability (0.79 at 4 days, 0.85 at 176). In regression, the expected number of owners rises with catalog size (clearly only above roughly 60 skills) and with path depth (a jump from 2 to 3). The unexpected result is the license: what matters is its **absence**. Repositories without a license (52% of the development contents, median of zero stars) host skills with 6.6 owners on average, against 3.7 for MIT, and the model predicts 1.48 against 1.29–1.30 for `log1p(owner_count)` for any license; they also have more `canonical` skills (34% against 24%). This is an exploratory finding, not an explanation of reuse: the mechanism is unknown, and it may reflect repositories created automatically or by installers rather than an effect of the missing license.

4.6 Model selection and tuning

Table 6: Nested validation (mean of 6 outer owner-grouped folds; 6 candidates per search).

Family	AUC default	AUC searched	RMSLE default	RMSLE searched
linear	0.678	0.689	0.692	0.690
KNN	0.667	0.690	0.703	0.686
tree	0.614	0.634	0.807	0.699
Random Forest	**0.716**	0.701	0.679	0.675
Gradient Boosting	0.691	0.704	0.690	0.671
HistGradientBoosting	0.693	0.682	**0.670**	0.688
baseline	0.500		0.720	

By the pre-specified rule we froze the default RF (classification) and the default HistGradientBoosting (regression). **Under the evaluated configurations, the families are not clearly separated:** the RF against the runner-up (searched Gradient Boosting)

differs by 0.012 AUC (95% CI [−0.003; 0.026]), and in regression the HistGB differs from the searched Gradient Boosting by −0.001 [−0.027; 0.024]. Only the tree (and, with less evidence, the default KNN) falls behind, and in classification even these differences do not survive Holm correction (p between 0.06 and 0.13). Intervals here are unadjusted 95% intervals; Holm adjusts only the p-values, within the family of comparisons of the best configuration against all others and the baseline. Non-significance reflects the limited resolution of 6 outer folds and does not establish equivalence. The search did not beat the default configuration (RF: 0.716 against 0.701).

4.7 Confirmation on the holdout

The frozen models were evaluated once on 25,011 contents from 10,484 owners, disjoint from development by representative owner.

Table 7: Single evaluation on the holdout (95% CI by owner bootstrap; HistGB is HistGradientBoosting).

Task	Model	Performance	Baseline
Classification (`cross_owner`)	Random Forest	AUC **0.731** [0.716; 0.745]	0.500
Regression (`log1p(owner_count)`)	HistGB	RMSLE **0.625**	0.664

Secondary metrics. Classification: PR AUC 0.913 [0.905; 0.921] (baseline 0.808), Brier score 0.140 (0.155), log-loss 0.444 (0.490). Regression: Spearman 0.330; RMSLE difference to the baseline −0.038 [−0.044; −0.032].

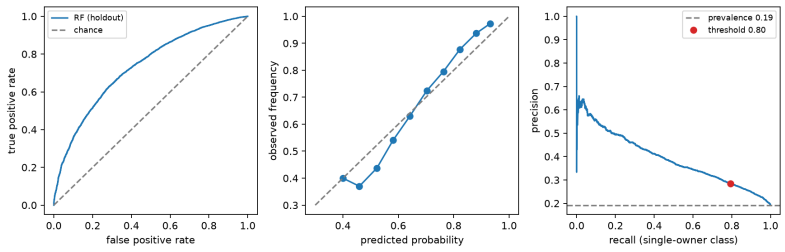


Figure 3: ROC curve, calibration and precision–recall curve of the single-owner (minority) class for the RF on the holdout

Both success criteria were met, and the holdout AUC (0.731) is consistent with the nested estimate on development (0.716). The holdout has a different composition (36% `canonical` skills against 21% in development, 9% `other` against 21%), since concentrated owners are left out by construction; H3 and H4 were not re-evaluated and remain exploratory.

Minority class and threshold. The PR AUC above refers to the majority class (80.8% prevalence), so it says little. For the minority class (content under a single owner, 19.2%), the PR AUC is 0.390 (95% CI [0.362; 0.418]), about twice its prevalence. The threshold that maximizes the balanced accuracy on development out-of-fold predictions

is 0.80 (the default 0.5 gives only 0.506 there). Applied unchanged to the holdout, it gives a balanced accuracy of 0.659 (95% CI [0.647; 0.670]), against 0.663 on development, with a recall of 0.79 and a precision of 0.28 for the single-owner class (3,816 of 4,809 true single-owner contents recovered, but 9,607 cross-owner contents flagged as single-owner). The model therefore **orders** contents usefully, but a threshold produces many false alarms, and it should not be used for automated decisions.

5 Discussion

5.1 What the signal means

Observable attributes of a skill and of its repository carry information about cross-owner reuse, but not much: an AUC of 0.73 on the holdout and a 6% RMSLE reduction relative to the mean of `log1p`. The result holds across nested validation, development robustness and the holdout, but it is a signal of **coarse ordering**: the Spearman of the regression model is 0.33, and at the threshold that maximizes balanced accuracy the model recovers 79% of single-owner contents with a precision of 28%.

The block analysis answers RQ3 with caution: skill (file structure) and repository (visibility and activity) carry complementary information for classification (AUC 0.65–0.67 each, 0.72 together; removing either from the full set lowers the AUC by 0.04–0.05), whereas catalog and path add little, and in regression the contributions are small and uneven (Section 4.3). Permutation importance and partial dependence associate cross-owner reuse mainly with **stars and forks** (stars give the largest permutation-importance decrease in the evaluated model, but the two are correlated and their individual shares are not separable) and with repositories whose **last push is old**, which is consistent with skills in more visible repositories, and in repositories that have been inactive for longer, being copied by other owners. The association admits more than one explanation (visibility that generates copies, accumulated exposure time, or repositories valued for containing skills that were already copied), and the data do not separate them. In the regression, what stands out is the **absence of a license** and, for large catalogs, the number of skills in the repository; the license result is an exploratory finding with unknown mechanism (Section 4.5), not a general explanation of reuse.

Cross-sectional, not prospective. Stars, forks and last-push date were measured after some or all observed copying could have occurred, so the association with stars and forks may reflect copies that raised visibility as much as visibility that attracted copies, and an old last push may reflect accumulated exposure time. This is not target leakage in the conventional sense, but the results do not show that these attributes would have predicted reuse before it happened (Section 1.2).

5.2 Implications for using GitSkills

The most solid contribution is methodological and answers RQ1. (1) **`location_class` and `history_fetched` are not legitimate predictors of reuse**: by construction, the representative's class grows with the number of copies (14% $\rightarrow$ 92%) and history inherits the dependence; including them makes the "repository" view look much more informative than it is (Section 4.2). (2) **Counting repositories mixes**

diffusion with self-copying; the number of owners is a more faithful target (a quarter of the reused contents have a single owner). (3) **Results depend on a few accounts**: the AUC varied from 0.615 to 0.747 with the treatment of owners with 500 to 1000 contents, so sensitivity to concentrated owners, or a cap per owner, should be standard practice. (4) **The representative describes an arbitrary copy**: among copies of the same class the choice is alphabetical, so repository attributes are those of one repository among several. Aggregates over all copies derive from the occurrences that define the target and should be avoided, or computed only from information prior to reuse.

5.3 Models and data limits

Under the families and the tuning budget evaluated (6 outer folds, 6 candidates per search, reduced for computational cost), the six families are not statistically separated in either task, apart from the tree and, less clearly, KNN, and the hyperparameter search did not help (default RF 0.716 against 0.701 searched). The linear models trail the forests by 0.02–0.04 AUC even after `log1p`, with intervals that include zero: this is a tie within the resolution of 6 outer folds, not proven equivalence. Increasing model flexibility did not consistently improve performance, but the data do not show that substantially better performance is impossible with more careful model selection, other architectures or alternative representations. A plausible reading is that the attributes describe one copy and the target is an exact count of hashes that ignores modified copies, so new information (relations among copies, time, richer representations) may be more promising than more flexible models; this remains a hypothesis.

5.4 Threats to validity and limitations

Construct. The number of owners approximates independent adoption only partly: it removes duplication by one account, but templates, catalogs and installation tools can still generate replication among owners. Forks are not a concern in these data (an audit found 8 occurrences in 3 fork repositories out of 3,797,117, none changing a `cross_owner` label; `results/owner/fork_audit.json`). Accounts may represent the same person or organization. Counts are lower bounds, the exact hash misses variants, and reuse by copying does not indicate use, quality or usefulness.

Internal. (i) H1–H4 were fixed after exploratory results; only the holdout is confirmatory. (ii) The cap of 50 per owner is data-dependent. (iii) Tuning used 2 repetitions of 3 folds and 6 candidates, fewer than planned. (iv) With 9 non-independent scores, the Nadeau–Bengio test is approximate, and Holm p-values depend on the family size. (v) **Residual selection effects:** excluding the shortcuts does not remove the influence of the representative rule, which still decides which repository supplies stars, forks, license, last push and the catalog and path attributes, and the number of copies may influence that selection; a check with a representative chosen independently of location would require attributes of alternative copies and was not feasible here. That the path barely helps and that the signal persists within each location class reduces, but does not eliminate, this risk. (vi) The threshold analysis is descriptive: it uses the saved holdout predictions. (vii) **Owner separation is partial.** Validation and holdout separate representative owners, but a content can appear under several owners: in 73% of the validation rows at least one

occurrence owner also appears among the occurrence owners of the training contents, and 51% of the holdout contents have an occurrence owner among the representative owners of the development contents (68% among all their occurrence owners). The models use no owner identifier, but the holdout does not test generalization to completely unseen owners.

External. The population is contents with at least two repositories, so the results do not apply to whether a skill is reused at all. The reported AUC is performance under the owner-capped protocol (Section 3.6), not an unrestricted ecosystem-wide estimate: the cap of 50 was chosen after seeing the AUC's sensitivity (0.615 to 0.747), and the holdout has no concentrated owners (at most 37 contents each) and more `canonical` skills (36% against 21%) than development, so the result does not extend to heavily concentrated owners. The corpus is a July 2026 snapshot of public repositories. The original test partition was used in exploratory analyses and supports no confirmatory claim. Near-identical variants of the same skill may still lie on both sides of the split.

Interpretation and ethics. Permutation importance and partial dependence are associative; correlation among attributes (stars and forks, several structure counts) can distribute importance unpredictably, and partial dependence can evaluate rare combinations, so strongest-feature statements are specific to the evaluated model and data distribution. They vary across folds; nothing here establishes causality. The data are public and GitSkills anonymizes commit authors; we omit owner identifiers, and the analysis does not aim to evaluate individuals.

6 Conclusion and future work

This work investigated whether observable characteristics of a skill and of its repository are associated with cross-owner reuse in GitSkills, and how much of this predictability is an artifact of the dataset's construction. Three conclusions hold.

First, GitSkills has construction biases that affect predictive studies. The rule that selects the representative makes the probability of it being in `.claude/skills/` grow from 14% to 92% with the number of copies, while the actual share of copies in that folder stays at 5–13%, so location and commit history are spurious predictors of reuse. In addition, about a quarter of the reused skills exist under a single owner and a few accounts concentrate the sample, so counting repositories overstates diffusion and performance depends on a few owners (AUC from 0.615 to 0.747 with the treatment).

Second, after excluding the identified construction-dependent shortcuts, the attributes predict cross-owner reuse with a modest signal confirmed on new data: on the holdout disjoint by representative owner, the Random Forest reaches an AUC of 0.731 (95% CI 0.716–0.745), and the HistGradientBoosting reduces the RMSLE of `owner_count` by 6% relative to the mean (0.625 against 0.664). Skill and repository attributes carry complementary information in classification, and the signal is associated with stars and forks, with older last pushes and, in the regression, with the absence of a license. At a decision threshold the balanced accuracy is 0.66 and the precision for single-owner content is 0.28: the model ranks rather than classifies. These figures describe an owner-capped sample, not the whole ecosystem, and do not extend to heavily concentrated owners; residual selection effects of the representative rule remain possible

(Section 5.4).

Third, under the evaluated model families and tuning budget, increasing model flexibility did not consistently improve predictive performance. This suggests that richer representations and improved measurements may be promising directions, although additional modeling gains cannot be ruled out. The claims are associative and cross-sectional (Section 1.2) and identify neither what makes a skill more or less copied nor its quality.

Future work. (i) Evaluate prospective prediction with attributes dated before the copies appear. (ii) Test robustness to the representative rule by choosing it independently of location, with attributes of alternative copies, and compare observation caps with inverse-owner-frequency weighting. (iii) Model at the copy level and group near-identical copies to mitigate the fragmentation of the target by exact hash. (iv) Investigate why repositories without a license host skills with more owners, and evaluate text representations within fixed location classes. (v) Propose to the GitSkills maintainers indicators that separate the representative choice from repository attributes.

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A Reproducibility and execution

Data, environment, seeds. Public source: GitSkills on Hugging Face, fixed revision `ebab17454a7c236f8f26b183567f1a126f42e3f8` (July 2026; SHA-256 verified). Python 3.12, `pyproject.toml` and `uv.lock`. Seeds: sampling `20261009`; validation 2027–2029; holdout `20261110`; bootstrap 2027. The 200,000-content sample is deterministic (`md5(content_hash || ':20261009')`). Code and data tables: github.com/podorize/skillreuse.

Quick reproduction (about 5 minutes, no 6.5 GB download). `make quick` uses the small derived tables in `data/derived/` (9.5 MB), runs the main protocol with one repetition and re-runs the frozen models on the holdout into a separate directory; the holdout numbers reproduce exactly. A Colab notebook is in `notebooks/reproduce.ipynb`.

Full pipeline.

```
uv sync
make data owner feature-eda
make controls primary robustness
make importance interpretation
make final holdout
make holdout-eval
```

The frozen models are in `results/owner/final/final_config_*.json`, committed before the evaluation (git tag `frozen-before-holdout`). `holdout-eval` writes `results/owner/holdout/evaluation_lock.json` and refuses to run again without `--allow-reevaluation`; any re-evaluation must be declared. Every table and figure maps to a CSV or JSON under `results/owner/` (and `results/controls/`), each directory with a `manifest.json`. `make robustness` also runs the block ablation, and `skillreuse owner-overlap` and `skillreuse fork-audit` reproduce the checks on owner separation (Sections 3.6, 3.9) and forks (Section 5.4). `make test` runs the tests.

Deviations and limits. Tuning used 2×3 folds and 6 candidates (planned 3×3 and 12) for computational cost, on a machine with 8 GB of memory. Earlier exploratory results (`results/count_regression`, `results/discipline_benchmark`) remain in the repository only as history. The protocol document `paper/protocol.md` is in Portuguese.

B Use of artificial intelligence tools

Claude Code [Anthropic 2026] (Anthropic) was used as an implementation and analysis assistant throughout the project: dataset audit, target and feature construction, validation and tuning code, holdout construction, tests, figures and drafting. The authors defined the research questions, approved each methodological decision (owner-based target, excluded attributes, per-owner cap, protocol, holdout and single evaluation), reviewed the outputs and are responsible for the code, the claims and the interpretation. Automated tests check the numbers reported in the text against the result files.